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BREW-BEATEN Clockwise from left, a country liquor vend near Bhopal; Congress leader Rahul Jaiswal; Inspector Dilip Puri, who was run over by a truck carrying illicit liquor in Dewas; former Sagar SP Anurag Sujania

MADHYA PRADESH

What's Behind the Hooch Tragedies

A series of tragic incidents reveals flaws in a liquor policy that keeps prices high, driving drinkers towards illicit brew

By **Rahul Noronha**

SUCH EPISODES ARE OFTEN THOUGHT to be the preserve of states with prohibition. The exceptions are usually marked by high taxation and retail prices, often laced with lax enforcement of industrial chemical controls. All three have a starring role in Madhya Pradesh, a state that is now logging hooch tragedies, and staccato bursts of violence around the illicit trade, with alarming frequency. Now it has also taken the local political vat to boiling point. All this despite the fact that the regular stuff flows freely.

The latest flashpoint: 10 people died in Dewas district between September 27 and October 16 after consuming what kinsfolk claimed was a locally sold brew. The heightened vigil that followed produced encounters—and not fake ones. As night fell between November 1 and 2, a truck loaded with liquor tried to cross Khategon, in that same district, and was stopped by cops. The fleeing truck driver crushed Inspector Dilip Puri under the rear wheels. Puri later died in hospital; the truck driver got a bullet in his leg on November 3.

A political twist preceded that. On November 2, Rahul Jaiswal, Khategaon Congress in-charge and seen as close to state chief Jitu Patwari, was arrested in the case—and named 'kingpin' by the police, along with a video 'confession' that he part-owns a local liquor shop. The Mohan Yadav regime needs the leverage; Dewas came close on the heels of the Sagar hooch tragedy in September, where over 25 died and hundreds were hospitalised. The last big one before these was Morena 2021, with 24 deaths and many losing their vision.

Takeaways

- **Two back-to-back hooch tragedies claim 35 lives**
- **Politics heats up as police arrest local Congress neta**

Why are tipplers preferring risky hooch when liquor is available? Excise sources say liquor demand has gone up, but the number of licensed shops is capped owing to political reasons. The social hypocrisy around drinking in India is consecrated as policy: the state officially claims to discourage it, but has a fondness for the touchings that arrive at the table. MP got Rs 17,600 in excise revenue last fiscal; it's expected to brim over to Rs 20,000 crore in FY27.

A HUGE MARK-UP

High taxes mean liquor is not competitively priced. A quarter of 'desi' takes about Rs 10 to brew, but costs Rs 65-70 at the shop. In Sagar, drinkers chose counterfeit IMFL that was cheaper by a mere Rs 20. Home delivery is popular in rural areas where the shop is too far. That ups the chances of hooch being sold through middlemen, '*kochiyas*'. Villages close to the forest also have mahua-based liquor, selling for as low as Rs 10 per glass. Many extol its virtue over factory-made country liquor, but it's also open to adulteration with chemicals and agents that add a kick.

Magisterial probes will unpack Dewas and Sagar; the latter also saw two accused being shot in the leg. There was collateral damage too: transfers of DMs and SPs. Among those, Sagar SP Anurag Sujania has quit: he'd been transferred out of Morena in 2021 too, and had rejoined service at Sagar. He won't be asking for another one. ■